POSTGRADUATE PROCESS MAPPING

Masters & PhD Programmes — Complete Workflow Reference

School of Information Communication and Media Stuides · Two Departments (CJM & IHRS)
Hackathon Design & Development Reference · For System Builders

1. Programme Structures Overview

1.1 Masters Programme

The Masters programme spans two years with four semesters in total — two per year. Year One is dedicated to coursework (taught classes). Year Two is dedicated to research and thesis development. The system begins active thesis pipeline monitoring at the start of Year Two, Semester One.

Phase	Sem 1 (Y1)	Sem 2 (Y1)	Sem 3 (Y2)	Sem 4 (Y2)
Focus	**Coursework**	**Coursework**	**Research**	**Research**
System Role	Admission recorded. Deferral tracking begins.	Monitor enrolment. Track deferral status.	**TRIGGER: Begin thesis pipeline monitoring.**	Track thesis stage progress & quarterly reports.
Quarterly Reports	Not required during coursework.	Not required during coursework.	Q-Report required each quarter. Multi-signature workflow triggered.	Q-Report required each quarter. Multi-signature workflow triggered.

> **DEFERRAL RULE** *A student may defer studies at any point. The system records the deferral date, sets the student's status to DEFERRED, and pauses all pipeline tracking and quarterly report requirements. When the student resumes, the system restarts from the exact stage at which the deferral occurred and recalculates all expected timelines from the resumption date.*

1.2 PhD Programme

The PhD programme spans three years. Year One and Year Two Semester One are coursework. Thesis development begins at Year Two Semester Two, giving the student approximately two and a half years of research time. The same thesis development pipeline applies as for Masters, but with additional supervisors (three vs two), and the external examination requirements are more detailed.

Phase	Sem 1 (Y1)	Sem 2 (Y1)	Sem 3 (Y2)	Sem 4 (Y2)	Sem 5 (Y3)	Sem 6 (Y3)
Focus	**Coursework**	**Coursework**	**Coursework**	**Research**	**Research**	**Research**
System Role	Admission recorded. Deferral	Monitor enrolment. Track deferral status.	Monitor enrolment. Track deferral status.	**TRIGGER: Begin thesis pipeline monitoring.**	Track thesis stage progress & quarterly reports.	Track thesis stage progress & quarterly reports.

Phase	Sem 1 (Y1)	Sem 2 (Y1)	Sem 3 (Y2)	Sem 4 (Y2)	Sem 5 (Y3)	Sem 6 (Y3)
	tracking begins.					
Quarterly Reports	Not required during coursework.	Not required during coursework.	Not required during coursework.	Q-Report required each quarter. Multi-signature workflow triggered.	Q-Report required each quarter. Multi-signature workflow triggered.	Q-Report required each quarter. Multi-signature workflow triggered.

1.3 The Two Departments

The School contains two departments. A student is registered to exactly one department. All departmental-level presentations happen within their registered department. School-level presentations are cross-departmental and convened by the School.

CJM	**IHRS**
Communication, Journalism and Media	Information Science, Health Records and Systems
Covers: Masters and PhD in Communication Studies	Covers: Master in IT, information Science and Health Informatics.Phd in IT

2. Student Status Model

2.1 Student Status Values

Every student in the system has one of four statuses at any time. Status determines which pipeline actions are available and whether notifications are triggered.

Status	Trigger	System Behaviour
ACTIVE	Default from admission	All pipeline tracking, quarterly reports, and notifications are live. Student appears on all dashboards.
DEFERRED	Student submits deferral request; approved by PG Dean	Pipeline tracking paused. Quarterly reports suspended. Student appears as DEFERRED on dashboards. No deadlines trigger.
DEFERRED	Student submits deferral request; approved by PG Dean	Pipeline tracking paused. Quarterly reports suspended. Student appears as DEFERRED on dashboards. No deadlines trigger.
RESUMED	Student notifies PG office of return	Tracking restarts from the stage at deferral. New expected timeline recalculated. Quarterly report cycle resumes.
GRADUATED	PG school issues graduation clearance	Student record archived. Appears on graduation roll. No further pipeline actions.

2.2 Deferral Tracking — Data Model

The system must capture the following for each deferral event:

- **Deferral date:** the date the student's studies are officially paused
- **Planned resumption date:** the semester the student intends to return (may change)
- **Actual resumption date:** the date the student officially resumes (recorded by PG office)
- **Reason for deferral:** health, financial, personal, work — recorded for PG reporting
- **Stage at deferral:** the exact pipeline stage frozen at the time of deferral
- **Quarterly reports suspended:** which report periods were skipped due to deferral (not overdue, just skipped)

> **SYSTEM RULE** *A student who defers after passing a presentation stage retains that pass. The stage is not reset. The system simply resumes from the next required action when the student returns. If a student defers while corrections are outstanding, those corrections remain pending on resumption.*

3. Thesis Development Pipeline — Detailed Stage Descriptions

The pipeline is divided into two phases: Pre-Field Work (concept note through data collection approval) and Post-Field Work (thesis presentation through graduation clearance). Each stage has defined gate conditions — requirements that must be met before a student can advance.

3.1 PHASE 1 — Pre-Field Work

Stage 1: Concept Note Presentation at Department Level

The student's first formal academic presentation. The concept note is a short document outlining the research idea, problem statement, and proposed methodology. Presented to a panel within the student's department (CJM or IHRS).

Item	Detail	System Action
Who presents	Student, in their registered department (CJM or IHRS)	System notifies: supervisors, department chair, panel members
Who assesses	Departmental panel: minimum 3 academic staff from the department	Assessment rubric submitted by each panel member; system calculates aggregate score
Outcome: PASS	Student advances to Concept Note at School Level	Pipeline stage updated. Supervisors and student notified. Presentation minutes recorded.
Outcome: FAIL	Student repeats at Departmental level. Corrections issued by chair from meeting minutes.	AI extracts corrections from transcript. Chair validates. Student receives checklist. Stage remains unchanged until corrections marked complete and resubmission scheduled.

Stage 2: Concept Note Presentation at School Level

If the departmental panel passes the concept note, the student presents to a school-level panel. This panel includes representatives from across the school (both CJM and IHRS may be represented). This is a broader academic scrutiny of the research idea.

Item	Detail	System Action
Gate condition	Must have PASSED Stage 1. Corrections from Stage 1 must be validated as complete.	System blocks Stage 2 booking until Stage 1 pass is recorded and corrections closed.
Outcome: PASS	Student advances to Departmental Proposal Presentation (Stage 3).	Pipeline updated. School-level minutes stored. Student and supervisors notified.
Outcome: FAIL	Student repeats at School level. May repeat departmental level too if panel requires.	Chair validates corrections. Repeat stage scheduled.

> **NOTE** *Some universities move directly from Concept Note (Dept) to Proposal (Dept) without a School-level Concept Note presentation. Confirm with your institution whether Stage 2 applies. The system should allow this stage to be toggled on or off in the programme configuration.*

Stage 3: Proposal Presentation at Department Level

The student now presents a full research proposal — a developed document covering literature review, conceptual framework, and methodology. The departmental panel reviews the proposal in detail and assesses whether the student is ready to proceed to school-level scrutiny.

Item	Detail	System Action
Gate condition	Passed Stage 2 (or Stage 1 if Stage 2 not applicable). Corrections closed.	System checks stage history and blocks booking if prerequisites unmet.
Outcome: PASS	Student advances to Proposal at School Level (Stage 4).	Minutes stored. Stage updated. Notifications sent.
Outcome: FAIL	Student repeats at Departmental Proposal level. Corrections issued.	AI corrections pipeline triggered. Checklist delivered to student.

Stage 4: Proposal Presentation at School Level

The most significant presentation before fieldwork begins. The school-level panel must be satisfied that the proposal is academically sound, the methodology is appropriate, and the student is ready to collect data. Passing here leads directly to a Postgraduate School approval process.

Item	Detail	System Action
Gate condition	Passed Stage 3. Corrections closed. Quarterly report(s) submitted and approved.	System validates quarterly report chain is complete before permitting Stage 4 booking.
Outcome: PASS	Student advances to Postgraduate School Approval (Stage 5).	Minutes stored. PG Dean notified to begin approval review.
Outcome: FAIL	Student repeats at School Proposal level.	Corrections pipeline triggered.

Stage 5: Postgraduate School Approval for Data Collection

Before a student may go to the field to collect data, the Postgraduate School must formally approve the move. This is an administrative review — not a presentation — and it requires a full document submission. The PG Dean reviews all documents and issues a Data Collection Approval Letter.

Documents Required for Data Collection Approval	
1	Completed and approved Quarterly Progress Report(s) — fully signed through the multi-signature chain (Supervisors → Dean → Finance)
2	Minutes of the successful Departmental Proposal presentation (Stage 3)
3	Minutes of the successful School Proposal presentation (Stage 4)
4	A signed letter of support from the student's primary supervisor
5	Completed student application form for field work clearance
6	Any ethics clearance documentation if the research involves human subjects

> **SYSTEM ACTION** *When all documents are uploaded and verified by the PG Office, the system routes a Data Collection Approval Request to the PG Dean. When approved, the system auto-generates the Data Collection Approval Letter and delivers it to the student. The pipeline stage advances to FIELD WORK.*

Stage 5b: NACOSTI Research Permit

Using the Data Collection Approval Letter issued by the Postgraduate School, the student applies to NACOSTI (National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation) for a research permit. NACOSTI is a Kenyan state corporation established by the STI Act of 2013. It regulates and licenses research conducted in Kenya, particularly research involving human subjects, communities, or sensitive data.

The student must obtain a NACOSTI permit before beginning any data collection in the field. The system tracks the NACOSTI permit status:

- **Pending:** student has received PG approval letter and is applying to NACOSTI
- **Received:** student has uploaded a copy of the NACOSTI permit to the system
- **Not Required:** for research that is desk-based or does not require a NACOSTI licence (admin can mark this)

> **DATA COLLECTION GATE** *The system should record the NACOSTI permit status but does not block field work based on it — this is a legal compliance requirement that the institution monitors. The PG office can see which students are in field work without a recorded NACOSTI permit and follow up.*

3.2 PHASE 2 — Post-Field Work (Thesis Stage)

Stage 6: First Draft Thesis Presentation at Department Level

After completing field work and data collection, the student presents the first draft of the full thesis to their departmental panel. The focus shifts from methodology approval to the quality of findings, analysis, and write-up.

Item	Detail	System Action
Gate condition	NACOSTI permit recorded (or marked Not Required). Quarterly reports up to date.	System checks field work stage is complete before permitting thesis presentation booking.
Outcome: PASS	Student advances to Thesis Presentation at School Level (Stage 7).	Minutes stored. Corrections (if any) issued via AI pipeline. Stage updated.

Item	Detail	System Action
Outcome: FAIL	Student must address corrections and repeat at departmental level.	Corrections delivered to student. Repeat presentation scheduled.

Stage 7: Thesis Presentation at School Level

The school-level thesis presentation is the final in-house scrutiny before the thesis goes for external examination. The school-level panel must be satisfied with the full thesis draft — including the quality of findings, discussion, and academic writing.

Item	Detail	System Action
Gate condition	Passed Stage 6. All thesis corrections from Stage 6 validated and closed. Quarterly reports current.	System validates prerequisites. Blocks booking if unmet.
Outcome: PASS	Student advances to External Examination (Stage 8).	School minutes stored. PG Dean notified. External examination document checklist activated.
Outcome: FAIL	Student repeats at School level after addressing corrections.	Corrections pipeline triggered.

Stage 8: External Examination Submission to Postgraduate School

Before the thesis goes to external examination, the Postgraduate School conducts a final administrative and academic compliance review. This is the most document-intensive stage in the entire process. The student must submit a complete bundle of evidence before the PG Dean releases the thesis to the external examiner.

Documents Required for External Examination	
1	A bound copy of the final thesis (or digital submission as specified by the institution)
2	All approved Quarterly Progress Reports for the full duration of the research period — fully signed
3	Minutes of successful Departmental Thesis presentation (Stage 6)
4	Minutes of successful School Thesis presentation (Stage 7)
5	Completed 'Intent to Submit' form — formally declares the student's readiness for examination
6	Letter from Head of Department confirming the student has submitted a journal paper to an indexed journal AND the paper has been accepted for publication
7	Evidence of participation in the Postgraduate Mentorship Programme (see below)
8	Proof of fee clearance for all years of study — confirmed via ERP Finance Module

> **POSTGRADUATE MENTORSHIP PROGRAMME** *This is a programme requirement where a postgraduate student teaches at least one course module to demonstrate academic competency in their subject area. The HoD must confirm participation in the letter submitted alongside the Intent to Submit form. The system tracks mentorship status as a student profile field: Not Started / In Progress / Completed.*

> **FEE CLEARANCE** *Proof of fee clearance is confirmed via the university's ERP Finance Module integration. The system sends a clearance request to the ERP and receives a confirmation. A student with outstanding fees cannot proceed to external examination.*

Stage 8b: External Examination Process

Once the PG School approves the document bundle, the thesis is sent to one external examiner and two internal examiners. The examiners review the thesis independently and submit their reports to the Postgraduate School.

- The system records the names and affiliations of the external and internal examiners (assigned by the PG Dean)
- The system tracks the examination status: Pending / Examiner Reports Received / Reports Reviewed
- When all examiner reports are received, the PG School schedules the Final Defence

Stage 9: Final Defence and Corrections

The Postgraduate School convenes a final defence meeting attended by the student, supervisors, internal examiners, and (where possible) the external examiner. Based on the examiner reports and the defence, the panel approves the student for graduation subject to specified corrections.

Item	Detail	System Action
Gate condition	All examiner reports received. PG Dean has reviewed. Final defence date set.	System triggers final defence scheduling workflow. Notifies all parties.
Outcome	Student approved for graduation subject to corrections specified by the panel.	Final corrections delivered via AI pipeline from defence transcript. Student receives checklist.
Corrections	Corrections submitted to supervisors for sign-off, then to PG Dean for final approval.	Corrections workflow tracked. When all approved, graduation clearance is triggered.

Stage 10: Graduation Clearance

When all final corrections are approved by the PG Dean, the system generates a Graduation Clearance record. This is the final output of the entire pipeline — it confirms the student is academically and financially cleared to be presented to the University Senate for graduation.

- Graduation clearance triggers the ERP Finance Module for a final fee confirmation
- The system generates a Senate-ready clearance certificate
- The student's status is updated to GRADUATED
- The full student record is archived with all stages, documents, and approvals preserved

4. Quarterly Progress Report Workflow

Quarterly Progress Reports are required throughout the research phase of the programme (Year 2 for Masters; Year 2 Semester 2 through Year 3 for PhD). They must be submitted every quarter and cannot be skipped or combined. Each report must pass through a defined multi-signature approval chain before it is considered complete.

4.1 Report Content

- Summary of research progress since the last report
- Objectives achieved during the quarter
- Challenges encountered and how they were addressed
- Plan for the next quarter

- Supervisor comments field — each supervisor adds comments before approving

4.2 Multi-Signature Approval Chain

#	Approver	Masters / PhD	System Action
1	Supervisor 1	Both	Notified immediately on student submission. Reviews and approves or returns.
2	Supervisor 2	Both	Notified when Supervisor 1 approves. Same action.
3	Supervisor 3	**PhD only**	Notified when Supervisor 2 approves. Same action. (Masters skips this step.)
4	Dean of School	Both	Notified when all supervisors approve. Reviews and approves or returns.
5	Finance (ERP)	Both	System calls ERP Finance API. Checks fee status. Returns approved or pending with note.

> **RETURNED REPORTS** *If any approver returns the report with comments, the system notifies the student, shows the comments inline, and restarts from that approver's position in the chain (not from the beginning). The student makes corrections, resubmits, and the chain continues.*

4.3 Quarterly Report Requirements for Stage Advancement

Certain pipeline stages require that all quarterly reports up to that point be fully approved before the student can advance. The system enforces this automatically:

- Stage 4 (School Proposal): all quarterly reports from the start of Year 2 must be approved
- Stage 5 (PG Data Collection Approval): same requirement
- Stage 8 (External Examination Submission): ALL quarterly reports for the entire research period must be fully signed — no exceptions

5. System State Machine — All Pipeline Stages

The following table defines every state in the pipeline, its gate conditions, and the transitions allowed. This is the data model for the student's current_stage field.

#	Stage Name	Gate Conditions to Reach This Stage	Possible Next Stages
0	**COURSEWORK**	Admitted to programme	→ CONCEPT_NOTE_DEPT (triggered at start of research year)
1	**CONCEPT_NOTE_DEPT**	Research year begun (Y2S1 Masters / Y2S2 PhD)	→ CONCEPT_NOTE_SCHOOL (PASS) OR → REPEAT_CONCEPT_NOTE_DEPT (FAIL)

#	Stage Name	Gate Conditions to Reach This Stage	Possible Next Stages
2	**CONCEPT_NOTE_SCHOOL**	Stage 1 PASS + corrections closed	→ PROPOSAL_DEPT (PASS) OR → REPEAT_CONCEPT_NOTE_SCHOOL (FAIL)
3	**PROPOSAL_DEPT**	Stage 2 PASS + corrections closed	→ PROPOSAL_SCHOOL (PASS) OR → REPEAT_PROPOSAL_DEPT (FAIL)
4	**PROPOSAL_SCHOOL**	Stage 3 PASS + corrections closed + Q-Reports approved	→ PG_DATA_COLLECTION_APPROVAL (PASS) OR → REPEAT_PROPOSAL_SCHOOL (FAIL)
5	**PG_DATA_COLLECTION_APPROVAL**	Stage 4 PASS + full document bundle submitted	→ NACOSTI_PENDING (on PG approval) OR remain until docs complete
5b	**NACOSTI_PENDING / FIELD_WORK**	PG Approval Letter issued	→ THESIS_DEPT (when NACOSTI received and field work complete)
6	**THESIS_DEPT**	Field work complete + Q-Reports current	→ THESIS_SCHOOL (PASS) OR → REPEAT_THESIS_DEPT (FAIL)
7	**THESIS_SCHOOL**	Stage 6 PASS + corrections closed + Q-Reports current	→ EXTERNAL_EXAM_SUBMISSION (PASS) OR → REPEAT_THESIS_SCHOOL (FAIL)
8	**EXTERNAL_EXAM_SUBMISSION**	Stage 7 PASS + ALL documents bundle + fee clearance	→ UNDER_EXTERNAL_EXAMINATION (on PG approval of bundle)
8b	**UNDER_EXTERNAL_EXAMINATION**	Document bundle approved by PG Dean, examiners assigned	→ FINAL_DEFENCE (when all examiner reports received)
9	**FINAL_DEFENCE**	All examiner reports received	→ FINAL_CORRECTIONS (after defence) → GRADUATION_CLEARANCE
10	**GRADUATION_CLEARANCE**	Final corrections approved + final fee clearance via ERP	→ GRADUATED (terminal state)

6. Hackathon Implementation Notes

6.1 Demo Setup

- Use two departments: CJM and IHRS. Seed at least 3 students per department across different pipeline stages.
- Seed one student with a DEFERRED status to demonstrate deferral tracking.
- Seed one student at Stage 8 who is missing a quarterly report — to demonstrate the gate blocking mechanism.
- Seed one student whose NACOSTI permit status is Pending to show monitoring.

6.2 Minimum Pipeline Stages for MVP Demo

1. Student sees their current pipeline stage and days elapsed
2. Admin sees all students across both departments with their stages
3. A presentation can be booked and scored — triggering a pass that advances the stage
4. AI extracts corrections from a transcript — chair validates — student receives checklist
5. A quarterly report is submitted and routes through the approval chain
6. A stage gate is blocked because a quarterly report is missing — and the system shows why

6.3 Field IDs for System Configuration

The following values should be seeded as constants in the system configuration:

- **School:** School of Communication and Information
- **Departments:** ['CJM — Communication, Journalism and Media', 'IHRS — Information Science, Health Records and Systems']
- **Pipeline stages:** The 10 stage names from Section 5 above (use the exact snake_case names as enum values)
- **Pass threshold:** 60% (configurable per stage in admin settings)
- **Masters supervisors:** 2 (Supervisor 1 + Supervisor 2)
- **PhD supervisors:** 3 (Supervisor 1 + Supervisor 2 + Supervisor 3)
- **Q-Report frequency:** Quarterly — one report per 3-month period during the research phase

End of Process Mapping Document

Refer to the Hackathon Design Brief (v2.0) for technical architecture and database schema details.

MASTERS PROGRAMME — COMPLETE THESIS PIPELINE (Phase 1: Pre-Field Work)

School of Communication and Information · CJM and IHRS Departments · Year 2 Semester 1 onwards

Department Level	School Level	Postgraduate School	External / NACOSTI	Fail / Repeat	Deferred Status	Graduation

PHASE 1 — PRE-FIELD WORK

YEAR 2 BEGINS
System triggers pipeline

▶ **CONCEPT NOTE (Department)**
CJM or IHRS Dept panel

▶ **PASS?**

▶ **FAIL**

▶ **REPEAT & CORRECTIONS**
AI extracts corrections
Chair validates Student checklist

▶ **CONCEPT NOTE (School)**
Cross-dept school panel

▶ **PASS?**

↓ PASS

▶ **PROPOSAL (Department)**
Full proposal dept panel

▶ **PASS?**

▶ **FAIL**

▶ **REPEAT & CORRECTIONS**
AI corrections checker

▶ **PROPOSAL (School)**
Q-Reports required

▶ **PASS?**

↓ PASS

▶ **PG SCHOOL APPROVAL**
Submit: Q-Reports Minutes · Supervisor letter

▶ **DATA COLLECTION APPROVAL LETTER**
Issued by PG Dean

▶ **NACOSTI PERMIT**
Student applies using PG letter

▶ **FIELD WORK (Data Collection)**
System monitors Q-Reports continue

▶ **→ PHASE 2**
Thesis development

KEY REQUIREMENTS AT EACH GATE

Concept Note → Dept PASS	Proposal School → PG Approval	PG Data Collection Approval	NACOSTI Permit
– Assessment rubric score ≥ pass threshold – Chair validates corrections from meeting minutes – Student marks all corrections as addressed – Supervisor confirms corrections complete	– Passed Departmental Proposal presentation – All corrections from Dept level closed – Quarterly reports fully approved – School assessment score ≥ threshold	– Minutes: Dept Proposal presentation – Minutes: School Proposal presentation – Approved Quarterly Reports – Supervisor support letter – Ethics clearance (if required)	– PG Data Collection Approval Letter – Student submits NACOSTI application – System tracks permit status – Field work begins — Q-Reports continue

MASTERS & PhD PROGRAMME — THESIS PIPELINE (Phase 2: Post-Field Work through Graduation)

Department Level	School Level	Postgraduate School	External / NACOSTI	Fail / Repeat	Deferred Status	Graduation

PHASE 2 — POST-FIELD WORK

FIELD WORK COMPLETE
From Phase 1

▶ **THESIS DRAFT (Department)**
Q-Reports current

▶ **PASS?**

▶ **FAIL**

▶ **REPEAT & CORRECTIONS**
AI corrections checklist

▶ **THESIS DRAFT (School)**
All dept corrections closed

▶ **PASS?**

↓ PASS

▶ **EXTERNAL EXAM SUBMISSION**
Full document bundle Fee clearance via ERP

▶ **EXAMINERS ASSIGNED**
1 External 2 Internal

▶ **THESIS UNDER EXAMINATION**
Examiners review independently

▶ **ALL EXAMINER REPORTS RECEIVED**
PG Dean reviews and schedules defence

FINAL DEFENCE MEETING
Student · Supervisors Examiners · PG panel

▶ **FINAL CORRECTIONS ISSUED**
AI extracts from defence transcript

▶ **CORRECTIONS APPROVED**
Supervisors → PG Dean sign-off

▶ **GRADUATION CLEARANCE**
ERP fee confirm Senate cert generated

▶ **GRADUATED**
Student archived Record preserved

EXTERNAL EXAMINATION SUBMISSION — COMPLETE REQUIREMENTS CHECKLIST

Document / Requirement	System Tracking
Bound / digital copy of final thesis	File upload tracked. Submission date recorded.
ALL approved Quarterly Progress Reports (full research period)	System checks report history. Blocks submission if any unsigned Q-report exists.
Minutes: Departmental Thesis presentation (Stage 6) — PASS	Auto-linked from Stage 6 presentation record in the system.
Minutes: School Thesis presentation (Stage 7) — PASS	Auto-linked from Stage 7 presentation record in the system.
Completed 'Intent to Submit' form	Digital form submitted through the system. PG Dean receives notification.

Document / Requirement	System Tracking
Letter from Head of Department — journal paper accepted AND mentorship programme completed	Letter uploaded by HoD through their dashboard. Status tracked as: Not Uploaded / Uploaded / Verified.
Proof of fee clearance for all study years (ERP Finance confirmation)	System calls ERP Finance API. Returns status: Cleared / Outstanding. Blocks submission if Outstanding.
NACOSTI research permit (or admin mark as Not Required)	Status field on student profile. Flagged on dashboard if Pending.

PhD DIFFERENCES FROM MASTERS — SUMMARY

Aspect	Masters	PhD
Duration	2 years (4 semesters)	3 years (6 semesters)
Coursework	Year 1 (Semesters 1–2)	Year 1 + Year 2 Sem 1 (Semesters 1–3)
Research begins	Year 2 Semester 1 (Semester 3)	Year 2 Semester 2 (Semester 4)
Supervisors	2 (Supervisor 1 + Supervisor 2)	3 (Supervisor 1 + Supervisor 2 + Supervisor 3)
Q-Report chain	Sup1 → Sup2 → Dean → Finance	Sup1 → Sup2 → Sup3 → Dean → Finance
Pipeline stages	Same 10 stages as described in this document	Same 10 stages — identical process
Mentorship	Required — must be completed before Ext. Exam	Required — same rule
Journal paper	1 paper submitted and accepted required	1 paper submitted and accepted required